Session 14

2025-06-22

1 - Baldur's Gate

~12:30, 5 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The barge ties up at the Baldur's Gate docks on the third day out from Elturel. The captain thanks the party for the hippo defence and river repairs, then walks the hull to a shipwright — she holds water but will not do another run without work. The city rules are clear at the pier: no draught animals, no carts inside the walls; cargo moves on porters' backs.
2. The scale of the port lands hard on those who have never seen a real city — stone quays, four-storey slate-roofed houses along the wharf, crowd noise thick enough to swallow a shouted conversation ten feet away. Amidamaru, veteran of Westgate, is the only one not startled by it.
3. The tortle pulls on a fresh elf-face illusion twice over — one casting for the meal, a second for the walk into the city.
4. Nyx warns him this is going to be the biggest city they will ever pass through: if he cannot walk this one, he cannot walk any. Amidamaru answers that big cities do not treat *different* kindly, and until a fight forces him out he will stay hidden.
5. After the meal on the docks the party spends the afternoon working the streets on foot — Amidamaru quietly taking the measure of the crowd; the rest learning the shape of the city.
6. By dusk they pick out a nearby tavern by its sign — a mermaid raising a jug — and head over: the *Blushing Mermaid*.

2 - Blushing Mermaid

~18:00, 5 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Inside, the room is packed and loud; each pays three gold for a room and full board — Amidamaru is nearly out of coin and Nyx covers his share. Nyx drops onto an open couch between two sailors on shore-leave; the loudest is a veteran whaler who introduces himself as **Hipocampus**.
2. The whalers invite her into dice at a silver a hand — five dice, highest sum wins. Nyx puts in a silver, rolls low, steps away — not enough coin to keep playing.
3. Nyx starts fishing for news: has anyone unusual moved through, anyone in strange robes? Hipocampus only knows what any sailor knows — trade from the south is thick, rumours of attacks in the green fields including a place called *Greenest*, and *"nobody has ever seen a dragon around here"*.
4. Mialee shows the whaler the cult's dragonclaw insignia — has he seen it? A pause; no. Amidamaru quietly confirms he was not lying.
5. Nyx presses him — a merchant contact, north gate, a name they were half-forgetting. Hipocampus knows it: **Ackyn Selebon**, a northern-gate merchant who outfits caravans; his shop is about an hour's walk north. The party parks the errand for the morning.

3 - Stranger at the back

1. Amidamaru has been noting the man alone at the back from the moment they walked in — hooded, huge, armoured under the cloak, taking up a whole table for one glass of wine. The party drifts over.
2. Only sharp eyes catch it at first, in candle-light and at close range: under the hood, more snout than face, and red. Eguzkilore offers a jug of beer as a peace-offering; Nyx raises her wine and toasts him.
3. Amidamaru sees a dragon face and pulls his sword back, drops into guard. *A dragon* — the party comes half up out of the seat with him. Nyx tries to hold the room: yes, he looks like Langdedrosa, but this one seems peaceful.
4. The tavern's two bouncers step in with steel out. Nyx intercepts — *sorry, misunderstanding, my friend was just showing his sword to a friend* — while Nuberroca slides behind the nearer bouncer and murmurs that this is a private conversation. The bouncer, half fear and half duty: *calm down, don't get so close, please behave*. Amidamaru sheathes; the bouncers step back, one lingering to watch.
5. Amidamaru pulls out the dragonclaw amulet and drops it on the table between them, watching for the reaction. Kaelthar looks up: *You are wearing a symbol that hangs like a sentence. Do you tell me you are guilty, or you are a martyr? Do you dare display that insignia, or do you seek provocation?*.
6. Amidamaru asks him to speak plainly, in a language everyone at the table can follow. The stranger names himself: *Kaelthar, warrior, paladin, more lethal than I look*. Kaelthar then names his hunt: anyone bearing that insignia.

4 - Fists in the street

1. Nuberroca puts a proposition on the table: no shields, no weapons, fists only. Kaelthar takes it; the pair walk out onto the port-side avenue rather than break the tavern. Nyx catches the bouncer on the way past: *they are only playing*.
2. Kaelthar draws a small ward of protection onto himself before the first exchange. Nuberroca throws the first punch with no guard up — it goes wide. Kaelthar's return lands solid to the ribs; Nuberroca tips into the roaring open-throated fury he keeps for the worst moments.
3. Kaelthar returns fire through the opening Nuberroca leaves him — a clean crack across the jaw; as the fist connects a small light flares along his knuckles, a divine burn folded into the strike, and Nuberroca spits blood. Nyx: *look, his fist is glowing*.
4. Two more exchanges. Nuberroca goes back reckless — one punch entering, one answered under a second flare of divine light — and by the third round he is bloodied and wobbling, a state none at the table have ever seen him in.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Kaelthar drops one last divine-burning strike and Nuberroca finally loses a fistfight for the first time in memory: still on his feet but battered, holding on rather than winning. Nuberroca concedes outright — *you have beaten me. My whole body hurts. How do you make your fists glow?*. Kaelthar answers that he swore an oath — a vengeance oath, against the very insignia the party had shown him at the table.
6. Amidamaru lays a hand on each and closes the worst of the cuts with a small casting — Nuberroca's wounds knit under a soft blue glow, Kaelthar's under a red one; the blood stays on the skin. Nyx offers Kaelthar her wine. Both men are still tender walking back in, and the bouncers watch them come in with a very different look than they had going out.

5 – The private room

1. The party pays a gold to close off the tavern's private back room for the evening; Amidamaru sweeps it for concealed listeners on principle. Walls thick enough that the tavern noise drops to a murmur; no windows.
2. Nyx asks the direct question: *how did you come to hate these people?*. Kaelthar answers as a paladin of the vengeance oath — a soldier of a clan of red dragonborn. In his own telling: a prophecy at his birth named him *the edge of the final fire*; a ceremony was arranged to unite his red clan and a white glacial clan against the cult of Tiamat; during the rite the glacial queen — a secret Tiamat priestess — killed the red-clan leaders and consumed their souls into a fragment of the goddess-dragon; Kaelthar survived three days buried under the sanctuary's rubble and cinders and eventually crawled out; he stood alone, marked by fury, and swore that no temple of Tiamat would stand, no traitor would go without judgement, no captive soul without redemption or destruction.
3. The party pays the story back with a compressed version — Greenest sacked by dragons, Langdedrosa Cyanwrath the half-dragon general beheaded (his head still hanging in Greenest); trouble in Elturel that ended in friendship with the Order of the Gauntlet and the Harpers; a contact they were sent to find north of Baldur's Gate.
4. Kaelthar names his own faction — *the Order of the Gauntlet*. Nuberroca peels back the skin over his coat, shows the matching insignia, and Kaelthar returns the sign in kind. Then, because it is *him*, Nuberroca tries to lift the paladin off his feet in a grip-hug to see how heavy he is. He passes on the reference to Ontharr — *the captain of the order. I beat him with my fists, you should fight him too*.
5. Kaelthar names his own errand: he is here to wait for a group of adventurers, escort them north to **Ackyn Selebon**, and infiltrate with them to uncover the plans of the Cult of the Dragon. Nuberroca, halfway out the door, doubles back — *that's the name I couldn't remember*.
6. Nuberroca announces Kaelthar is in as far as he is concerned, tells the others they can confirm in the morning, and takes himself off to bed. Amidamaru stays behind to press Kaelthar for anything more on their business — has he heard of a tortoise in his travels? — and the paladin admits he has not been looking for that. The rest drift out to eat, taking supper up to the room; before Nyx sleeps she readies a fresh set of Goodberries for the next day.

6 – Under the hood

~08:00, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party is down at eight for breakfast: cold meat, hard bread, toasted pieces, beer — Mialee asks for a cup of milk and gets one more curd than milk, dairy does not travel well.
2. Amidamaru, having drawn the wrong eyes yesterday even with the elf-face, tries a different tack: a walking cloak deep over the shell so nothing of his shape reads clearly. The attempt goes badly — the hood makes him more conspicuous, and by the time the party is on the street heads are turning, guards are looking longer, the crowd is stepping around him. Kaelthar picks it out at once — a heavily burdened person under a very odd cloak, something moving underneath — and asks him plainly, *who are you?*.
3. Amidamaru drops the cloak just enough for Kaelthar to see: *this is my real form — the same problem you have, hard to show in public. I don't usually show it in big cities. I'm taking a risk, and I don't like it*. Kaelthar answers as one outsider to another: *that is what it feels to be a stranger among many*.

7 – Black Dragon Gate

1. Following the flow of porters through the crowded street is enough to reach the north gate without directions. Amidamaru and Nuberroca are the first to catch what the others miss — several faces among the porters at the gate register from a past encounter, back at Greenest or the cult's camp or on the raiders' road.
2. Amidamaru summons his owl. **Munin** wheels down onto the rooftops and settles into a long circle overhead — birds common enough here that no one looks up. Amidamaru watches through Munin's eyes and his own at once.
3. Nuberroca picks a porter he half-remembers — *hello, what are you doing here?* — the porter tries to shake him off. Nuberroca sidles closer and, on the excuse of helping with the bundle, hooks a finger under and lifts it. Something metallic clinks inside the sack the porter has just insisted is grain. Nuberroca, quieter: *this does not sound like grain — if you want to keep talking straight, talk.*
4. Mialee slips an invisible magic hand in beside the covered palanquin the same group is escorting, and — as if a small gust had caught it — lifts a corner of the cover. Amidamaru, at oblique distance, sees under and turns away without a word: inside sits a black dragonborn. He and Nuberroca pull back into the group.
5. Nyx pings each of the others with a short mind-to-mind whisper — *come back, distance, we do not want them tying you to the rest of us*. Nuberroca lets the porter go and pulls back; half a dozen furtive glances follow him.
6. At a middle distance, they compare notes: black dragonborn in the palanquin, cultists' faces among the porters, ten or twelve moving as a unit. Nyx puts the question — infiltrate as planned, but Nuberroca has already been marked — how do we play this?. The party keep their spacing and follow the palanquin to a warehouse-inn used by merchants waiting for a caravan; it shuts behind them. Munin passes overhead but finds nothing to perch on that isn't a giveaway.

8 – Ackyn Selebon's shop

1. The party enter the shop across from the gate; Nuberroca uncovered, the rest in travel gear. The merchant recognises the emblem on Nuberroca's tabard — *are you the Ontharr ones?* — and slots into helping them at once. He is worried they cut it close: the group they came for arrived a few days ago, are refusing to hire guards or carts locally — *which is peculiar if not impossible* — and have been packing for two days. Best guess: they roll out today or tomorrow, from an inn at the end of the street on the left — where the party has just seen the palanquin disappear.
2. The merchant does not go out on the road himself, but offers his name as reference to the caravan's other merchants and can supply gear and horses. The caravan is bound north to **Waterdeep**. The frame: several merchants pool for a run, each with 3-8 guards, total 30-40 for the group. Two roads north: the direct route through *The Trollclaws*, or a longer detour east via *The Fields of the Dead*, then back north through the Trade Way.
3. Nuberroca cashes in a greataxe, a scimitar and a broadsword at half-price; Amidamaru sells a crossbow and its bolts, keeping the quiver. Amidamaru asks the merchant to arrange a letter to Westgate — direct messenger would be almost three hundred gold, a hand-off across trade caravans four or five with no guarantees. He takes the caravan option, four gold, and marks the letter sent.

9 – Contracting on

1. Outside, the party spread out to shop themselves in. Nyx counts five merchants working the crowd: **Lai Angesstun**, a dwarf — oil-and-perfume merchant from Amn, short-handed and agitated, wanted to be on the road already; **Edhelri Lewel**, an elf-woman trading in exotic woods; and **Noohar Serelim**, a second elf — standing quiet next to a wagon of carved wood, travelling with his mute brother **Selvek**.
2. Each hire lands on a demonstration. **Kaelthar** carries a flexing demonstration for Lai. **Nuberroca** opens Edhelri with a polite bow (*good afternoon, dear elf, we come to offer ourselves as soldiers of fortune*), and **Amidamaru** drives a stagecraft display alongside — shadow-blade in his hands and a wizard's blade-song through the air, Nuberroca hopping in as stage-hand. **Mialee** arrives at the tail of the negotiation and puts an arrow clean through an illusion-target thirty feet out for Noohar.
3. When the dust settles, Lai has hired the largest slice of the party — Kaelthar as bodyguard at 10 gold a week, Nyx as sergeant at 8, and Eguzkilore as guard at 5. Edhelri contracts Mialee as her bodyguard at 10 and Nuberroca as her sergeant at 8. Noohar takes Amidamaru as his bodyguard at 10, with the standing condition that Amidamaru protects him *and his brother*.
4. Wages per-week, paid week-in-arrears, plus food and shelter on the road and paid nights when the caravan stops in a village with a bed. **Sinsong** travels as a paying passenger rather than on contract.

10 – Trail preparation

~11:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The larger caravan carts are almost finished loading; the suspected cultist has three carts readied but their palanquin is nowhere to be seen. Even so, the cultists stay apart from the rest of the caravan — their porters stay attached to their own group rather than joining the shared pool, walk-in guards looking for work are turned away, and no one from their contingent mixes with the other merchants.
2. When the wheels turn: ten carts on the road — five with merchants, two with travellers riding along, three with the suspected cultist contingent — protected by 30-35 warriors between guards, sergeants and bodyguards.
3. On the merchant's warning — no re-supply on the road, no smith to re-shaft a broken blade — the party lay in trail-stock. Nyx picks up a fresh longbow-string, Mialee a handful of arrows and a couple of spare strings, Eguzkilore nine long-shaft arrows. Kaelthar takes a spare longsword against the day this one takes damage. Prices per usual — one gold per twenty arrows, fifteen gold per longsword.
4. Nyx breaks out ten Goodberries as lunch — one each, enough to hold hunger through the afternoon so no one has to walk back across the city.
5. With most of an hour still to fill, the party breaks for a short rest and a quiet meal — most already at full strength, but all settle in for the road ahead.
6. At around half-past one the carts begin to move. Sinsong is nowhere to be seen; the caravan heads north without him.